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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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Lowering costs of products has risks

As consumers clamor for relief, economists say there's a downside

BY JULIE ZAUZMER WEIL

Americans keep saying it: They want lower prices.

Grocery prices have swelled 25 percent in the past five years. The average price of a new car just topped \$50,000. Energy bills are soaring, as are health care premiums and child care costs. And housing has come up as much as 30 percent since 2020, for both renters and buyers.

Inflation was a defining issue of the 2024 election and helped propel Donald Trump's return to the White House after he promised to bring down consumer prices the day he took office. But a year later, it's a drag on his approval ratings: 59 percent of Americans give Trump either a great deal or a good amount of blame for the current rate of inflation, according to a Washington Post-ABC News-Ipsos poll. In an attempt to reduce grocery prices, Trump just rolled back some of his own tariffs on certain foods, including bananas and coffee.

The problem is, there's generally no going back once prices rise. And for good reason.

Retailers don't reduce prices unless there's a significant drop in demand, such as during periods of high unemployment. "As

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Prized pinot noir taken in wine theft

Chase ensues after bottle valued at \$24,000 stolen from Virginia restaurant

BY DAN MORSE AND EMILY HEIL

Escorting the couple through his restaurant's high-end wine cellar, Christian Borel grew uneasy — the woman with her rapid-fire questions, the man with his long overcoat wandering in and out of view.

As the three walked back upstairs, Borel couldn't shake the feeling. He raced back down and spotted them: screw-top replacements where his finest wines had once been.

Borel ran back up. "Stop them!" he shouted. "They're stealing the Romanée-Contis!"

And the chase was on. Borel and three other staff members, joined by a patron in a Porsche, headed outside to try to catch the couple heading for their getaway car in the bucolic Shenandoah Valley wine country 60 miles west of Washington.

The take: six bottles of French pinot noir the restaurant valued at \$38,000.

SEE WINE ON A17



PHOTOS BY SALWAN GEORGES/THE WASHINGTON POST

Pearl industry in Japan faces crisis

Warming waters, aging farmers endanger survival of once-thriving family businesses

BY MICHELLE YE HEE LEE, CHIE TANAKA AND SALWAN GEORGES

AGO BAY, JAPAN — For generations, a string of perfectly round, classic white pearls — the kind worn by fashion icons like Audrey Hepburn and Jacqueline Kennedy — has been the epitome of understated class.

The lustrous "akoya" coveted around the world for their timeless beauty, originated here, in the calm waters and sheltered inlets of Ago Bay, where conditions are ripe

for oysters to thrive.

But after 130 years, Ago Bay's pearl industry is facing a double-whammy existential crisis: Warming waters are endangering oysters, which are growing weak and susceptible to a deadly virus. Aging farmers are struggling to find successors for their small, family-owned businesses.

Akoya pearl oysters are carefully tended by farmers using techniques passed down through generations.

After being artificially fertilized and incubated in tanks,

SEE JAPAN ON A14

ABOVE: Akihiro Takeuchi, a third-generation pearl farmer, seeds pearls inside his lab at the family farm in Mie, Japan, a process he likens to an organ transplant. RIGHT: His wife, Chigusa Takeuchi, tends to their oysters in Ago Bay.



Methane-eating microbes could devour pollutant

Researchers are testing the tiny organisms at farms and landfills to reduce a powerful greenhouse gas

BY ALLYSON CHIU

PETALUMA, CALIF. — The cows had to be deterred from messing with the experiment.

Researchers from a Bay Area technology company had come to the sprawling dairy farm north of San Francisco to test an emerging solution to planet-warming emissions: microscopic pink organisms that eat methane, a potent greenhouse gas.

Kenny Correia, 35, of Correia Family Dairy, watched the team from Windfall Bio working near the lagoons used to store manure from the farm's several hundred cows. The researchers erected a futuristic system of vats, pipes, tubes and shiny metal supports. Then, when everything was assembled, they poured pink liquid into one of the vats. "They were looking like mad scientists out there," Correia recounted.

He acknowledged initially thinking it was a "crazy idea" to integrate an outdoor laboratory into a working farm. There was

SEE MICROBES ON A10



CHRISTIE HEMM KLOK/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Correia Family Dairy in California hosted a trial of a new way to control methane emissions: microscopic organisms that eat the potent greenhouse gas, which cattle produce in large quantities.

Hegseth targets foes of Trump

PENTAGON JOINS BID AGAINST CRITICS

Experts say effort poses threat to U.S. democracy

BY NOAH ROBERTSON, TARA COPP AND SARAH ELLISON

After Donald Trump was elected to a second term last year, a retired Army general who'd been critical of the president in the past made a list of the ways that the incoming administration could come after him, should he speak out again.

He identified three scenarios: a civil suit, an IRS audit, or a recall to active duty where, conceivably, he could face criminal charges in the military's justice system.

The retired general, speaking on the condition of anonymity out of fear of retaliation, recalled that exercise after Trump's defense secretary, Pete Hegseth, said Monday that the Pentagon will investigate Mark Kelly, a Democratic senator from Arizona and retired Navy officer, for his role in making a controversial video reminding service members of their duty to disobey unlawful orders.

Trump's "retribution campaign," the retired general said, has had a significant "chilling effect."

SEE HEGSETH ON A7

DHS sweep of Chicago nets few with record

Aggressive tactics bring 4,000 arrests, but most aren't violent criminals

BY ARELIS R. HERNÁNDEZ, MARIANNE LEVINE AND MARIA SACCHETTI

CHICAGO — Juan Manuel Armenta was at a bus stop en route to pick up his paycheck when he was approached by several armed men. The Department of Homeland Security had just started "Operation Midway Blitz" and was surging immigration officers into the city. On that September afternoon, Armenta became one of their first arrests.

Three days later, DHS included Armenta's mug shot in a press release titled "Pedophiles, Abusers, Rapists, and Other Violent Thugs Arrested." It described Armenta, who concedes he crossed the border illegally more than three decades ago, as a "criminal illegal alien" with arrests for armed robbery and drunken driving. The release did not mention that the 2013 DUI allegation had been reduced to reckless driving and that police had declined to charge him in the 2006 armed

SEE CHICAGO ON A8

IN THE NEWS

A papal visit Pope Leo XIV went to Lebanon, long a Christian stronghold, as the religion's population declines there because of conflict and economic strife. A13

Fast food free-for-all This ultramarathon combines a 50-kilometer run — and the occasional stop for tacos. C11

THE NATION **Texas's designation** of a Muslim advocacy group as a terrorist organization has sparked backlash. A3
Some states offer publicly funded child care, but coverage varies. A6

THE WORLD **Indian outreach** to the Taliban has ratcheted up Afghan-Pakistan tensions. A12
Hundreds are dead or missing after a tropical cyclone caused flooding in Southeast Asia. A13

THE ECONOMY **An investor** has argued that the poverty line should be far higher, leading to debate among economists. A16

STYLE **The rise** of lab-grown diamonds has reshaped engagement ring norms, but don't ask if they're "real." B1

Cory Booker, long considered one of the most eligible bachelors in Congress, was married at ceremonies in D.C. and New Jersey. B1

SPORTS **Mississippi** football coach Lane Kiffin said he will take the open job at LSU. C1

THE REGION **Bill Ferguson**, Maryland's Senate president, has faced backlash for blocking a mid-cycle redistricting plan. C11

HEALTH & SCIENCE **A lab at Ohio State** University is developing the food dyes of tomorrow using plant-based materials. D1

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